

CRITERION 1 — QUALIFYING DIAGNOSIS

The requested lumbar spine MRI must be supported by a diagnosis consistent with one of the following conditions: lumbar radiculopathy, suspected herniated nucleus pulposus, spinal stenosis with neurogenic claudication, cauda equina syndrome, or suspected spinal infection, fracture, or malignancy. Diagnoses outside this list require additional clinical justification and may not be approved through standard review.

CRITERION 2 — CONSERVATIVE THERAPY

For non-emergent presentations, the requesting provider must document a minimum of six weeks of conservative treatment, including physical therapy, oral analgesics or NSAIDs, and activity modification, without adequate improvement in symptoms, prior to approval of advanced imaging. Requests submitted without this documentation will be returned as insufficient unless a qualifying exception applies.

CRITERION 2 EXCEPTION — RED FLAG SYMPTOMS

The conservative therapy requirement described in Criterion 2 is waived when any of the following red flag findings are clearly documented: new bowel or bladder dysfunction, saddle anesthesia, progressive motor weakness, suspected cauda equina syndrome, fever with suspected spinal infection, a history of cancer presenting with new back pain, or significant trauma with suspected fracture. When a red flag is present, imaging may be approved without prior conservative treatment.

CRITERION 3 — SUPPORTING CLINICAL FINDINGS

The request must include relevant physical examination findings that support the qualifying diagnosis, such as a positive straight leg raise test, documented motor weakness, asymmetric reflexes, or a sensory deficit following a dermatomal pattern. Diagnosis alone, without supporting examination findings, is not sufficient for approval.

CRITERION 4 — PRIOR IMAGING

If a lumbar spine MRI was already performed for the same condition within the preceding twelve months, the current request must document a significant change in clinical status, such as new neurological findings or substantial worsening of symptoms, to justify repeat imaging. Requests for repeat imaging without a documented change in status will not be approved.